

TECHNOLOGY ENTREPRENEURSHIP
BIOGRAPHIES AND PRODUCTS OF TECHNOPRENEURS



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1. William Tanuwijaya (Tokopedia)

William Tanuwijaya was born on November 11, 1981, in Pematang Siantar, North Sumatra, to a middle-class family that highly valued education. After completing his high school education in his hometown, William moved to Jakarta to continue his studies at Bina Nusantara University (BINUS). He then went on to pursue further studies at Harvard Kennedy School.

While studying at BINUS, William faced difficult times when his father fell ill during his second year of college. In order to continue his studies, he worked as a night internet cafe attendant until morning, about 12 hours per night, and spent his free time there to gain a deep understanding of the internet world. After graduating in 2003, William worked at various technology companies, starting as a software developer at TelkomSigma, Sqiva Sistem, and Bolehnet (as a game developer), until finally serving as IT & Business Development Manager at Indocom Mediatama in 2006.

The inspiration to establish Tokopedia came in 2007, when William was moved by the need to provide an online platform that connects sellers and buyers throughout Indonesia. He invited his friend, Leontinus Alpha Edison, to be his co-founder. Even though his family was in a precarious situation, his father was diagnosed with cancer. William continued to persistently seek capital. He faced many rejections, but remained optimistic and did not give up.

On February 6, 2009, Tokopedia was officially established, and it was publicly launched on August 17, 2009, coinciding with Indonesia's Independence Day. In the following years, Tokopedia grew rapidly: in October 2014, it received USD 100 million in investment from SoftBank Internet and Media and Sequoia Capital, and in 2017, it received USD 1.1 billion in funding from Alibaba Group, making it an Indonesian unicorn.

William has also received various awards for his dedication and innovation. He was named a Young Global Leader (World Economic Forum) in 2016. In 2019, he was awarded the Satyalancana Wira Karya by the President of Indonesia in recognition of his contributions to the development of technology and the Indonesian economy.

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2. Narendra Wicaksono (Dicoding)

Narendra Wicaksono, fondly known as Naren, is a pioneer in the field of technology education in Indonesia as the founder and CEO of the Dicoding learning platform. He was born and raised in Bandung, and later studied at the Bandung Institute of Technology (ITB), majoring in Information Technology.

During college, Narendra was active in organizations. He served as Chairman of the ITB Information Technology Student Association and was part of Microsoft Student Partner, a program that brought him closer to the global technology and developer ecosystem. His talent even led him to win awards such as the Imagine Cup Regional Indonesia in 2006. For his achievements, he was awarded the Microsoft Most Valuable Professional (MVP) award shortly thereafter.

After graduating, his career took off. In May 2007, Narendra was appointed IT Pro Evangelist at Microsoft Indonesia, developing IT infrastructure and even designing a Terminal Services Web Access demo for the launch of Windows Server 2008 by Steve Ballmer. A few years later, he moved to Nokia as Developer Marketing Manager, where he again gained recognition through the Intel Innovator award.

After eight years of gaining experience at Microsoft and Nokia, Narendra felt called to build a digital talent ecosystem in Indonesia. He founded Dicoding in early 2015 (officially launched on January 5, 2015), with the aim of bridging app developers with industry needs through educational platforms such as Academy (classes), Challenge (challenges), Events (events), and Job Platform.

Since its launch, Dicoding has achieved various accomplishments. The platform has attracted more than 140,000 developers from around 454 cities, involved more than 800 startups as members, organized hundreds of offline events, and produced more than 5,200 digital works such as applications and games, with a total of more than 225 million downloads.

Naren doesn't just think about the business side of things; he also believes that Dicoding is a means of spreading kindness and opening up opportunities. He once said that his family's support, despite coming from a civil servant background, gave him the confidence to take

the leap into entrepreneurship. He admits that he was afraid to leave the comfort zone of his career, but believes that sustenance is not about quantity, but rather the blessings within it.

Furthermore, from childhood to adulthood, Narendra has always been known for his enthusiasm for technology. In junior high school, his father bought him a Macintosh Classic computer, and Narendra managed to connect it to the internet. This experience made him realize the enormous potential of technology. Since then, he has continued to hone his skills and creativity in programming, eventually choosing to pursue education and a career in technology.

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3. Sid Sijbrandij (GitLab)

Sytse Sijbrandij, better known as Sid, is the visionary behind GitLab, an open-core DevOps platform that now serves more than 30 million registered users worldwide (with over 1 million active licensed users).

Sid was born and raised in the Netherlands. He studied at the University of Twente, earning a Master of Science in Management Science between 1998 and 2003. From a young age, he was interested in technology and pursued various creative opportunities—such as building recreational submarines while working at U-Boat Worx between 2003 and 2007.

Sid's career is unique and multidimensional. He worked as Director of Operations at U-Boat Worx, then became an architect on the Legis project at the Ministerie van Justitie en Veiligheid (Dutch Ministry of Justice and Security), which developed innovative web applications to assist with legislation. It was here that he first became interested in programming when he saw Ruby code for the first time in 2007—and taught himself to build software from there.

In 2012, Sid discovered the open-source GitLab project created by Ukrainian developer Dmytro Zaporozhets. He was so inspired that he immediately contacted the creator to build a website for the project. His passion for open source then led him to enter the world of tech startups.

Sid officially commercialized GitLab and entered it into the Y Combinator accelerator program (Winter 2015 batch). Since then, GitLab has grown rapidly without a physical office, becoming one of the largest remote-first companies in the world, with thousands of employees spread across more than 60 countries.

Sid led GitLab as CEO until the end of 2024, before transitioning to the role of Executive Chair of the Board. Under his leadership, GitLab made history with a successful IPO in 2021. Its stock surged approximately 35% on the first day of trading, propelling Sid to billionaire status with a net worth of around USD 2.6 billion.

Sid is known as a pioneer in the values of transparency, openness, and fully remote collaboration. GitLab is known for its handbook, an internal document, that is open, living, and spans over 2,000 pages. It is not just a guide but also the foundation of the company's

culture and internal recruitment. GitLab rejected a USD 10 million acquisition offer to prioritize long-term growth and strategic control, even going so far as to adopt a dual-class share structure bef.

In addition to leading GitLab as Executive Chair, Sid founded and leads Open Core Ventures as General Partner, and serves as Director of the Sijbrandij Foundation, a philanthropic venture addressing major issues such as clean energy, urban development, and health. He is also a member of the GitLab Foundation, which focuses on expanding access to education and global economic opportunities.

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4. Fabien Pinckaers (Odoo)

Fabien Pinckaers was born in 1979 in Ottignies, Belgium, the son of Michel Pinckaers, an antiquarian, and Françoise Richel. He studied at UCLouvain (Université catholique de Louvain), majoring in Computer Science or Information Technology, where from a young age he showed a talent for both technology and business.

His interest in programming emerged during his teenage years. At around the age of 13, Fabien created his first business management software, which he later sold to local companies such as Les Transports Verts and the Belgian Writers' Association. During his studies, he developed several projects: Auction-in-Europe, an art auction platform that achieved higher transaction figures than eBay in Belgium; and Openstuff, an online Linux store that sold merchandise such as T-shirts and posters.

In March 2002, Fabien launched his ambitious project, TinyERP, while still a student. This project evolved into OpenERP a few years later, eventually changing its name to Odoo—a new name that reflected a broader vision of creating a suite of integrated business applications, not just ERP. He led the company from the beginning as its sole employee, and in less than eight years—before turning 31—it had grown into a multinational company with offices on three continents and more than 100 employees.

Over time, Odoo has grown rapidly. In 2013, the company was named one of Belgium's fastest-growing companies in the Deloitte Technology Fast50, with 1,549% growth over five years. In 2014, OpenERP officially changed its name to Odoo.

Odoo achieved Wallonia's first unicorn status in 2021. In November 2024, the company's valuation reached more than 5 billion euros, making it one of Belgium's most successful unicorns. By 2025, Odoo had more than 5,500 employees and offices in various cities around the world, including San Francisco, Mexico City, Hong Kong, Dubai, Nairobi, and Gujarat (India).

In interviews and coverage, Fabien is described as a leader who is very focused on the product. Despite serving as CEO, he still allocates about 50% of his time to product development, working directly with the developer team—a hands-on approach that is rarely seen at the executive level. He applies a philosophy of high efficiency: quick

decisions, minimal hierarchy, and an internal culture free of unnecessary meetings and convoluted reporting. This operational model is supported by a strong community and a global partner network that now exceeds 7,500 partners in over 120 countries.

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5. Stewart Butterfield (Slack)

Daniel Stewart Butterfield—born Dharma Jeremy Butterfield on March 21, 1973—is a Canadian entrepreneur and developer known as the co-founder of Flickr and founder of Slack

Butterfield was born in Lund, British Columbia, and grew up in unique circumstances—his family lived in a remote commune in a cabin without running water or electricity for the first five years of his life. His father fled to Canada to avoid conscription into the Vietnam War. At the age of seven, he was introduced to computers—an Apple IIe—and taught himself programming

His formal education was also quite unique: he earned a BA in philosophy from the University of Victoria in 1996, then a Master of Philosophy from Clare College, Cambridge in 1998. These studies shaped his critical and argumentative thinking skills, which have been very useful in his career.

After graduating, Butterfield worked at the startup Gradfinder.com with Jason Classon, which was later sold at a healthy profit despite the sluggish tech economy following the dot-com bubble. In 2002, together with his wife (later ex-wife) Caterina Fake and Classon, he founded Ludicorp and created an online game called Game Neverending. When the game failed, they turned the idea into a photo-sharing platform that became Flickr—a revolutionary Web 2.0 service that achieved great success and was acquired by Yahoo! in 2005.

After leaving Yahoo! in 2008, Butterfield founded Tiny Speck and developed the game Glitch, which unfortunately also failed in the market. However, the internal communication they built during the game's development was eventually turned into a new product: Slack (the name was later expanded to “Searchable Log of All Conversation and Knowledge”). Slack was publicly launched in February 2014 and immediately achieved rapid growth.

In building Slack, Butterfield emphasized the importance of user feedback and always listening to customer needs as the center of product strategy. The platform was designed to replace email as the primary communication tool in the workplace—and achieved widespread adoption from large companies such as NASA, Airbnb, and others. Despite

facilitating communication, Butterfield acknowledged challenges such as the potential for text-based miscommunication and message overload—problems for which solutions are still being sought.

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FIGURES COMPARISON

1. How to Innovate or Create Products

- **William Tanuwijaya (Tokopedia)**

His innovation stems from the needs of Indonesians who have difficulty accessing financial products and services. He built a marketplace that empowers MSMEs to sell their products online. His focus is on economic inclusivity.

- **Narendra Wicaksono (Dicoding)**

His approach is more edutech-oriented. He saw a gap between the needs of the digital industry and the skills of local talent. His innovation was to create a curated coding learning platform and partner with large companies such as Google and Microsoft. His focus is on talent development.

- **Sid Sijbrandij (GitLab)**

His innovation was born from open source practices. He built GitLab not only as a tool for version control, but also as an end-to-end DevOps platform that enables remote team collaboration. His focus is on the efficiency of global developer collaboration.

- **Fabien Pinckaers (Odoo)**

He saw a gap in the market where traditional ERP software was very expensive and difficult for small businesses to access. So he created Odoo as a modular open source ERP solution that can be used by small businesses and large companies alike. His focus is on democratizing business software.

- **Stewart Butterfield (Slack)**

His innovation is unique because Slack was born from a pivot. Initially, he created an online game, but it failed. From that failure, he saw that internal team communication tools could be turned into a product. Slack became a very popular business communication platform. His focus is on communication and work productivity.

2. Product Impact

- **Tokopedia (William Tanuwijaya):** Empowering millions of MSMEs in Indonesia, boosting the national digital economy.
- **Dicoding (Narendra Wicaksono):** Creating thousands of new developers, narrowing Indonesia's digital divide.

- **GitLab (Sid Sijbrandij):** Used by global companies for software development, accelerating global technological innovation.
- **Odoo (Fabien Pinckaers):** Becoming an affordable ERP solution, used in various countries by millions of business users.
- **Slack (Stewart Butterfield):** Changing the way companies communicate, becoming one of the main tools in the remote work era.

3. Who Has Had the Greatest Impact?

When viewed locally (in Indonesia), William Tanuwijaya and Narenda Wicaksono have had a major impact because they directly solved highly relevant problems: market access for MSMEs and the need for digital talent education.

However, when viewed globally, Sid Sijbrandij (GitLab) and Stewart Butterfield (Slack) have a greater impact because they have changed the way developers and companies work around the world. Fabien Pinckaers (Odoo) is somewhere in the middle—his scale is global, but he is stronger in certain business segments (ERP).

In my opinion, Sid Sijbrandij (GitLab) has had the most widespread impact, because GitLab is used not only by small startups but also by large global companies, while promoting a remote-first work culture that has become increasingly relevant after the pandemic. However, in the Indonesian context, William Tanuwijaya has clearly had the most tangible impact by paving the way for the local digital economy.

MOST ADMIRABLE FIGURES

Of the five tech entrepreneurs studied, I admire Sid Sijbrandij and Narendra Wicaksono the most. They have different backgrounds, but there is a common thread in their life stories, namely their persistence in building something that has a broad impact on the community.

Sid Sijbrandij is the figure behind GitLab, an open-source software development platform. He changed the way technology teams around the world collaborate in writing code, enabling thousands and even millions of developers to contribute transparently. What I admire about Sid is his courage in building a large company with a remote-first model, long before remote working became a global trend. This demonstrates his vision and belief that technology is not just about products, but also about how people work more efficiently and inclusively. From Sid, I learned that great innovation comes from the courage to be different and hold fast to the principle of openness.

Meanwhile, Narendra Wicaksono, through Dicoding, focuses on developing digital talent in Indonesia. Dicoding is not just an online course platform, but a learning ecosystem that encourages the nation's youth to compete globally. I am impressed because Narendra started from a real concern: the lack of access and opportunities for many Indonesian developers to obtain quality technology education. With his consistency, Dicoding has produced tens of thousands of digital talents who now contribute to various large technology companies. From Narendra, I learned about the importance of building solutions from local problems and the enormous impact of education on social change.

When compared, Sid has a global impact through software development infrastructure, while Narendra has a direct impact on human resource empowerment in Indonesia. Both inspire us that innovation can arise from both global-scale solutions and local needs.